INTERVIEW-PREP PACKET 3 OF 5 · PER-INTERVIEWER · BUSINESS-PROCESS LENS

Amazon NACF Supply Chain loop — Packet 3: Rocky Goforth

Amazon — Senior Supply Chain Manager, NACF Supply Chain (L6)

Rocky Goforth

Senior Manager, Infrastructure — NACF

Thursday, October 30, 2026 · 10:00 am PDT · 55-minute video interview

> **Strategy in one line.** An infrastructure owner wants to know what happens when the plan meets the floor. Open with S2 (one comingle pool instead of two warehouses, a robotics ramp behind a published 98% gate that fired at 94, two go-lives with zero customer-facing incidents) and hold S18 (dual-DC WMS migration: 0.5% tolerance published before mock one, 7% → 1.8% → 0.3%, the RF-device miss owned) for the go-live-gone-wrong / Bias for Action question. Gates, invariants, triggers and hypercare numbers are the vocabulary; vendors configured, DC Ops ran the floor.

LP focus — my guess, not confirmed: Insist on the Highest Standards · Bias for Action · Deliver Results or Ownership. Amazon does not disclose the assignment; the guesses are reasoned from the interviewer's title and the JD in "Read me first" and should be held loosely. No interviewer biography is asserted anywhere in this packet — only title-based inference, labeled as such.

Canon: amazon/amazon-l6-scm-master-packet.html (§1.2 roster, §4.1 ledger). Every number below is that packet's value; every dollar carries its basis label (record · user anchor · modeled · priced).

Read me first

The interviewer's lens (inference from title + JD — not a biography)

Inference from the title. "Infrastructure" in a fulfillment network means the physical and systems substrate the process runs on — buildings, automation and robotics, the WMS/WCS layer, capacity and launches, cutovers and peak readiness. A Senior Manager there is accountable for changes that touch the floor: go-lives that cannot drop a shipment, automation ramps that must not erode throughput, and migrations where inventory accuracy cannot wobble. He will care about gates, rollback, freeze windows, hypercare exits, and what happened when the plan met the floor.

What that means for the answers. The two Sephora distribution-center programs: S2 (two systemic warehouses in one building consolidated into one comingle pool, with a WMS upgrade and a robotics ramp on the same critical path and zero customer-facing incidents allowed) and S18 (a dual-DC legacy-WMS migration run to a 0.5% reconciliation tolerance published before the first mock, with the RF-device miss owned). Tell them as Make/Deliver process redesigns — one inventory pool instead of two, a cutover discipline instead of a date — with asset utilization (+15% processing efficiency, labor-hours, capital pooled) and reliability (zero incidents, 0.3% against 0.5%) as the results. The vendor teams configured BlueYonder and Locus; DC Ops ran the floor; I owned the model, the staging, the gates and the go/no-go.

Three guessed LP focus areas, with rationale

> **Labeled guess.** Amazon assigns 2–3 Leadership Principles per interviewer and does not disclose them. These three are inferred from the title and the JD; if the first question lands on a different LP, the twist maps under each story carry the pivot.

GUESSED LP	WHY THIS INTERVIEWER WOULD CARRY IT	STORY TO OPEN · BACKUP
Insist on the Highest Standards	Infrastructure owners live by gates that can stop the program: the 98% robotics gate that fired at 94 (S2) and the 0.5% tolerance published with Finance before mock one (S18) are the primary and backup for this LP in the master map.	S2 (open) · S18 (backup)
Bias for Action	When the floor breaks the plan — a quarter of the RF devices failing the conversion script at cutover — he wants to see a rehearsed contingency fire and a decision taken the same day with the cost priced.	S18 (the paper-pick fallback) · S2 (the throttle to ~30%)
Deliver Results / Ownership (one of the two)	Two go-lives, peak untouched, +15% signed by DC Ops; an eight-month migration on time and ~3% under budget with a $20M pipeline unblocked. Ownership shows in the RF miss carried with my name on the cause.	S2 (the comingle launch) · S18 (8 months, both DCs)

Answer strategy — business first, systems as enablers

- **Open with the process problem and its cost, not the system.** First sentence names the broken process (Plan, Source, Make, Deliver or Return), who it hurt (customer, Finance, the floor) and the baseline number. The platform appears only as the enabler of the redesign, in one clause.
- **Use the JD's four outcome words as the results frame:** reliability (did the promise hold?), responsiveness (how much earlier did we see it?), cost efficiency ($ with its basis label), asset utilization (capital, labor-hours, capacity released).

- **Action = operating-model redesign in gated phases** — Discovery → Plan & Design → Build & Test → Cutover → Hypercare, each spoken as entry bar · what I delivered · exit bar. Say the gate that fired, not the meeting that happened.
- **Every dollar carries its basis word in the same breath** — record · user anchor · modeled · priced. A record dollar is said flat; a modeled dollar is said with its inputs. Never promote a modeled number to record.
- **Program-lead voice.** I owned definitions, rules, gates and the signature chain; engineers, SIs and vendor teams configured and built to the spec I signed. The only platform personally configured in canon is Manhattan DOM.
- **The pitch ends on the primary metric.** Then stop. Silence after the pitch is the interviewer filling their STAR worksheet; their probes are the second half of the answer.
- **For Infrastructure specifically:** speak in gates, invariants and triggers — the published ramp gate and the throttle built in advance; the six cutover invariants (Σ AFS conserved; no SKU sellable in two places; negatives cleared first); rollback triggers as numbers (sync < 99% for 4 h; p95 > 2× for 1 h); hypercare exit as a number (< 2 blockers/day sustained). A gate that cannot stop the program is decoration.
- **Asset utilization is the result frame:** +15% units per labor-hour (signed), one pool instead of two (√2 pooling, modeled and labeled), self-transfers inside one roof eliminated, robotics at full volume by week three, $20M of pipeline unblocked on the date.

Loop-consistency rule. One question, one story; never the same story to two interviewers — interviewers compare notes. Held for other packets (do not spend here): S11/S12 (Tripathy) · S6/S8 (Hoerger) · S1/S3 (Lan) · S16/S15/S10/S14 (Josyula). S5 (the architecture council) shares the UDC program's dated chain with S2 — Lan's backup pointer, not yours; S2 and S1 share program-level artifacts (issues log, rollback triggers) — if asked, say so.. If pushed for "another example" on an LP, use the named backup in the question bank or the backup bench at the end of this packet, never a story allocated to another interviewer.

How to read the "L6 level evidence" block under each story. Amazon's L6 functional bar (user-supplied rubric): *Ambiguity* — strategy or network undefined; I select the stakeholders, set the goals, deliver independently. *Scope & influence* — team-level scope; influences one to two levels up. *Execution* — tactical and strategic; simplifies or extends; applies best practices; force-multiplies; mitigates long-term risk; makes the short-versus-long-term trade-off explicit. *Impact* — long-term team goals. *Process improvement* — operational-excellence best practices institutionalized. *Complex* — visible risks, roadblocks and constraints mitigated through expertise, judgment and influence to consensus. Overview themes the block is tuned to: designing and modeling the supply chain rather than working in it; developing new processes for others to own; root-cause mechanisms that resolve trending issues at scale; recommendations to leadership that outline competing metrics. The block sits right after Results so the evidence is on the page when the probing starts.

The stories — business-first, canon numbers

Two Sephora distribution-center programs. Each: 60-second pitch → Situation/Task → Action in gated phases → Results → Probing tuned to an infrastructure owner → the key math → Twist map.

S2 — Sephora Utah DC — two systemic warehouses in one building → one comingle pool, coupled with a WMS upgrade and a robotics ramp behind a published gate (+15% processing efficiency, zero customer-facing incidents)

LPs this story can serve here: Insist on the Highest Standards (primary — the 98% gate that fired at 94) · Deliver Results (two go-lives, peak untouched) · Have Backbone (the throttle) · Strive to be Earth's Best Employer (the floor protected during the ramp) · Bias for Action (the throttle decision the week the gate failed)
Process family: Make / Deliver — DC operating model (one inventory pool, three planning identities), automation ramp governance, staged go-lives, cutover runbook, hypercare exit

Honesty label. I owned discovery through FSD for the location and inventory model, the staging and the gates; BlueYonder, Locus and the platform teams built and configured; DC Ops ran the floor and measured the +15% post-stabilization. The +15% is Sephora's signed number; every dollar is my model on an illustrative 100K-units/week DC. Program-level artifacts (dated gate chain, 836-row issues log, rollback triggers) are shared with S1/S5 — one umbrella program.

60-SECOND BUSINESS-FIRST PITCH — STOP ON THE PRIMARY METRIC

Situation. Sephora's Utah DC ran as two systemic warehouses in one building — Dotcom 801 and Retail 901 — transferring stock to itself and paying duplicate handling for zero customer value. The ask was one omni comingle facility, with a BlueYonder WMS upgrade and Locus robotics on the same critical path, an October–December peak freeze, a dozen core systems and 20+ touched, 60+ stakeholders, and zero customer-facing incidents allowed. **Task.** I owned discovery through the signed design for the location and inventory model, the staging and the acceptance gates. **Action.** I redesigned the operating model as one physical pool with three planning identities, so each channel kept its forecasting lens without a second truth; split the program into two go-lives so each carried one defect class — January proved reserve rules against live demand with the floor untouched, May moved warehouse execution; published the robotics gate at 98% pick-accurate throughput with the throttle dial built in advance and owned by DC Ops; ran three mock cutovers against the 0.5% tolerance and a 343-task runbook whose one irreversible instant was zero-then-publish, so nothing was sellable in two places. When week two of the robotics ramp hit 94 against 98, the gate fired: bots throttled to about 30% of volume for a week, zone and slotting logic root-caused, full volume week three. **Result.** Primary metric: DC processing efficiency — baseline index 100 → 115, +15%, Sephora-signed, measured by DC Ops post-stabilization; zero customer-facing incidents through both go-lives; rollback armed twice, never fired. About $1.6M a year modeled — labor at +15%, pooling carry, fewer split shipments, self-transfer handling removed — and about $2.2M of one-time safety stock released by pooling, also modeled; the +15% and the zero are the record.

SITUATION / TASK — THE BUSINESS PROCESS PROBLEM, SCOPE, SCALE, BASELINES

S — The Utah DC ran as two systemic warehouses — Dotcom 801 (selling location 800) and Retail 901 — transferring stock to itself and paying duplicate handling for zero customer value. The ask: one omni/comingle facility, with a BlueYonder WMS 8.2 → 2023.1 upgrade and Locus robotics on the same critical path, a dozen core systems (20+ touched), an Oct–Dec peak freeze, zero customer-facing incidents allowed.

The challenges sat on the critical path itself: the WMS upgrade and the robotics ramp shared it, the peak freeze bounded it, and the interim would run two live truths. The register's top three risks — two live truths during the interim, a robotics ramp with no stop condition, and a peak collision — each had a trigger, a mitigation and an owner before sign-off.

T — Discovery through FSD for the location and inventory model, the staging and the acceptance gates; 60+ stakeholders (~80 names across ~15 functions) on the steering path; none of the systems reported to me.

Baselines on the table: processing efficiency index 100 (units per labor-hour) · customer-facing incidents allowed: 0 · robotics gate 98% published in advance from the pre-ramp baseline and the incident budget · self-transfers and duplicate handling — the standing cost one pool exists to remove.

ACTION — THE PROCESS / OPERATING-MODEL REDESIGN, IN GATED PHASES

- **Discovery (3/29 → 4/30)** — profiled 801/901 (SKU overlap, order profiles); sponsor objectives and success criteria — one omni facility, self-transfers eliminated, zero customer-facing incidents, peak untouched; systems-impacted table. *Exit bar:* every impacted system named to an owner with a written LOE (landed 7/2); criteria signed by steering.
- **Plan & Design (5/15 → 8/14)** — council pack (three decisions + an out-of-scope fence); the 900/901 location/inventory model with three planning identities over one physical location; staged two-go-live timeline; RAID log; FSD 8/14. *Exit bar:* council sign-off 7/31; FSD 8/14; peak-freeze boundary decided; LOE-backed plan across ~30 build tracks.
- **Build & Test (Aug → Jan/Apr)** — node × channel × bucket-transition matrix as the regression asset; dated E2E days — Inbound 11/22, Dotcom 12/20, Retail 1/30 — every function in one room; Locus gate definition (98%) with the throttle spec; three mock cutovers against the 0.5% tolerance (the S18 discipline reused); the Locus RTL slipped three weeks — escalated the week it surfaced, re-slotted openly, UAT not compressed to absorb it. *Exit bar:* E2E green on three dates; Blocker + Critical open = 0 at each go/no-go; mock 3 inside tolerance.
- **Cutover & Go-Live (January; May 1 → Jul 1)** — runbook of 343 tasks / ~815 hours, each with owner, duration and predecessor; six-step May choreography — clear negatives, transfer AFS to Uncommitted, scan-and-reserve, zero-then-publish; rollback triggers per interface (sync < 99% for 4 h; order-flow p95 > 2× budget for 1 h). *Exit bar:* six invariants held (Σ AFS conserved; no SKU sellable on 800 and 900 at once; negatives cleared first); rollback never fired.
- **Hypercare / Close (Jun → Jul)** — daily burn-down 271 → 65 → 21 → 14 → 4; Locus weekly gate read — week 2 at 94 vs 98 → throttle to ~30% → RCA (zone/slotting logic) → full volume week 3; hypercare exit memo; template handed to the next DC. *Exit bar:* < 2 blockers/day sustained → exit week 3 of 4; +15% measured post-stabilization by DC Ops.

Influence and ownership. Mine: the location/inventory model, the staging, the gates, the council pack, the runbook and the go/no-go recommendation. BlueYonder, Locus and the platform teams built and configured; DC Ops ran the floor, owned the robotics gate and the dial before the ramp — so when it fired, the rule fired; I did not improvise. Digital worried a virtual Retail DC would blur their forecasting lens — the three-identity design made the concern the design rather than an argument. The comingle-reserve improvements were held out of the release to protect zero incidents, priced as a later enhancement at steering.

> **Designed the process; others own it now.** I designed the location/inventory model, the gates and the throttle dial; DC Ops owned the dial before the ramp and runs the floor on it, and the hypercare template went to the next program.
> **Trade-off put to leadership.** The recommendation to leadership outlined the competing metrics — +15% processing efficiency and the robotics ramp vs zero customer-facing incidents and peak untouched — and made the gate (98%) and the throttle (~30%) the published answer before the robots arrived.

RESULTS — $ · # · % · TIME · CUSTOMER · QUALITY (CANON NUMBERS ONLY)

- **$** — ≈$1.6M/yr *modeled* (labor at +15% ≈$0.88M · pooling carry ≈$0.22M · fewer split shipments ≈$0.45M · self-transfer handling ≈$0.10M) + ≈$2.2M one-time safety-stock release *modeled* via √2 pooling; the +15% is Sephora's signed number; every dollar is my model on an illustrative 100K-units/week DC (range $1.1–2.4M/yr).

- # — cutover runbook 343 tasks / 48,885 task-minutes ≈ 815 hrs; issues log 836 rows / 85.4% closed; burn-down 271 → 65 → 21 → 14 → 4 (record).
- **%** — processing efficiency +15% (record, Sephora-signed); robotics gate 98%, week 2 at 94, bots throttled to ~30% of volume for a week, full volume week 3 (record).
- **Time** — council 5/15 → sign-off 7/31 → FSD 8/14; E2E 11/22 · 12/20 · 1/30; January and May go-lives; hypercare exited week 3 of 4 (record).
- **Customer** — zero customer-facing incidents through both go-lives (record) — the constraint every other number moved inside.
- **Quality** — six cutover invariants held; rollback armed for both go-lives, never fired; peak untouched (record).

L6 LEVEL EVIDENCE — what the interviewer pattern-matches against the Amazon L6 functional rubric; every line is this story's canon, no new numbers

L6 DIMENSION	EVIDENCE IN THIS STORY
Ambiguity	Two systemic warehouses in one building and no agreed operating model. I owned the location/inventory model (three planning identities over one physical location), the staging and the gates, and set the success criteria with the sponsor — one omni facility, self-transfers eliminated, zero customer-facing incidents, peak untouched.
Scope & influence	BlueYonder, Locus and the platform teams built and configured; DC Ops ran the floor and owned the robotics gate and the dial; the go/no-go recommendation was mine to leadership — influence across a dozen core systems and 60+ stakeholders I did not manage.
Execution trade-off + mechanism others now own	Robotics throughput vs floor stability: the 98% gate fired at 94 in week 2, bots throttled to ~30% for a week, full volume week 3. Mechanism others own now: the dial, owned by DC Ops before the ramp, and the hypercare template handed to the next program.
Impact (long-term)	Processing efficiency +15% (Sephora-signed); zero customer-facing incidents through both go-lives; ≈$1.6M/yr modeled plus ≈$2.2M one-time modeled; peak untouched.
Process improvement (standard work institutionalized)	The node × channel × bucket-transition matrix as the regression asset; a runbook of 343 tasks / ~815 hours with owner, duration and predecessor; six cutover invariants; a daily burn-down 271 → 4.
Complexity & consensus	Staged two go-lives (January planning / May execution) so each carried one defect class; a peak-freeze boundary; dated E2E days (11/22 · 12/20 · 1/30) with every function in one room.
Root cause at scale	The week-2 robotics miss was root-caused to zone/slotting logic and fixed before full volume — the rule fired, the cause was removed, the ramp was not pushed through.

PROBING — CHALLENGE Q&A TUNED TO THIS INTERVIEWER

> **Infra — Why 98%, and what did you actually do at 94?**
>
> 98% was set from the pre-ramp baseline and the incident budget before the event, and DC Ops owned it. At 94 in week two I throttled the bots to about 30% of volume for a week, root-caused the zone and slotting logic, and ramped again — full volume by week three. A gate that cannot stop the program is decoration; mine did.

> **Infra — Why two go-lives instead of one big one?**
>
> So we never hunted two defect classes in the same week. January proved reserve rules against live demand while the floor was untouched; May left warehouse execution as the only remaining class. One go-live would have put a reserve defect and a floor defect in the same room.

> **Infra — What made you say go in May?**
>
> Counted rows, not the room: Blocker + Critical at zero, mock 3 inside the 0.5% tolerance, the 343-task runbook rehearsed, rollback armed per interface. I would have said no-go on one open Blocker; I never had to.

> **Infra — What were the rollback triggers and did any fire?**
>
> Sync below 99% for four consecutive hours, or order-flow p95 above twice budget for one hour — rollback per interface behind them. Armed for both go-lives; never fired. The one irreversible instant was step 4, zero-then-publish, so no SKU was ever sellable in two places.

> **Infra — The labor number is the biggest piece of your $1.6M. How firm?**
>
> The fifteen percent is measured and signed; the 120 FTE and the $28 loaded rate are my assumptions. Pull the DC's direct hours for the two quarters before and after and multiply by payroll — that turns the model into a record in an afternoon. If the split-shipment row didn't move, the total is about $1.1M.

> **Infra — What would you do differently?**
>
> Staff the interim reporting workstream on day one, not month three — for four months every report had to declare which system of record it read. And the Locus slip: escalated the week it surfaced, but I would have put the RTL on the register as a risk, not a task, from the start.

THE KEY MATH — THE +15% TO HOURS, THE POOLING RELEASE, AND THE THROTTLE ARITHMETIC (RECORD PERCENTAGES; ILLUSTRATIVE VOLUMES LABELED)

STEP	QUANTITY	FORMULA → SUBSTITUTION	BASIS	VALUE
1	Efficiency	`index 100 → 100 × 1.15 = 115`	record (Sephora-signed, post-stabilization)	+15%
2	Hours for the same volume	`240,000 / 1.15 = 208,700; saved 31,300 h = 13.0%`	120 FTE × 2,000 h illustrative on a 100K-units/week DC	31,300 h/yr
3	Labor dollars	`31,300 × $28 = $876,400`	$28 loaded (modeled; benchmark $24–32)	≈$0.88M/yr modeled
4	Pooling release	`$7.5M × (1 − 1/√2) = $7.5M × 0.293 = $2.2M; carry $2.2M × 10% = $0.22M`	√2 pooling on duplicated poolable safety stock (illustrative $50M × 25% × 60%)	≈$2.2M one-time; ≈$0.22M/yr
5	Split shipments / self-transfers	`45,000 × $10 = $0.45M; 260,000 × $0.80 × 50% = $0.10M`	modeled (softest rows)	≈$0.55M/yr
6	Robotics gate	`T = 94% < 98% → throttle: bot share 100% → 30%; manual covers 70,000 of 100,000 units/wk`	gate record; volume illustrative	RCA, full volume week 3
7	Total	`0.88 + 0.22 + 0.45 + 0.10 = $1.65M/yr + $2.2M one-time`	modeled	≈$1.6M/yr (range $1.1–2.4M)

Steering charter: one omni facility · self-transfers eliminated · zero customer-facing incidents · peak untouched — all four delivered.

Where this lands at Amazon. An FC launch/retrofit with automation on the critical path: publish the ramp gate and the throttle before the robots arrive, stage go-lives so each carries one defect class, hold peak sacred, and write the rollback as a number. Zero-then-publish is the same discipline as never letting one unit be promisable from two nodes at once. Asset utilization (+15% units per labor-hour; one pool), reliability (zero incidents, rollback never fired).

TWIST MAP — LIKELY LP QUESTIONS FROM THIS INTERVIEWER → THE ANGLE TO TAKE WITH S2

LIKELY QUESTION (THIS INTERVIEWER)	LP	ANGLE — WHAT TO EMPHASIZE	SKIP / NEVER SAY
Tell me about a time you held a high standard when it was costly.	Insist on the Highest Standards	The 98% gate fired at 94; a week of robot volume traded for a root-caused ramp; full volume week three.	Do not say "the robots failed" — the gate worked as designed.

LIKELY QUESTION (THIS INTERVIEWER)	LP	ANGLE — WHAT TO EMPHASIZE	SKIP / NEVER SAY
Tell me about a time you had to slow something down.	Have Backbone / Bias for Action	The throttle to ~30% the week the gate failed — a decision the same week, owned by DC Ops' own rule.	Do not frame it as caution; it was a pre-built dial firing.
Tell me about launching something with zero room for error.	Deliver Results / Customer Obsession	Zero customer-facing incidents through both go-lives as the constraint; two go-lives so each carried one defect class; the six invariants.	Skip the Kafka/ESB topology unless asked.
How did you protect the floor / the people during the change?	Earth's Best Employer	The throttle protected the floor's throughput; DC Ops owned the gate and the dial; the interim's reporting burden named as the price.	Do not invent a headcount or an attrition figure; none exists in canon.
How do you plan a cutover?	Functional — launch readiness	Runbook with owner/duration/predecessor per task; one irreversible instant identified; rollback triggers as numbers; three mocks against a tolerance; hypercare exit as a number.	Never "400 devices failed" (that is S18's RF miss — ~100 of ~400).
What's the ROI of the consolidation?	Frugality	+15% signed; ≈$1.6M/yr modeled with the four rows and their inputs; ≈$2.2M one-time pooling, labeled textbook.	Never present the $1.6M as a signed number.

S18 — Sephora — legacy WMS → JDA WMS dual-DC migration: a 0.5% reconciliation tolerance published before mock one, three mocks read by cause class (7% → 1.8% → 0.3%), and the RF-device miss owned

LPs this story can serve here: Insist on the Highest Standards (backup — the published tolerance) · Bias for Action (the rehearsed fallback fired, the date held) · Deliver Results (backup — 8 months, both DCs, gate cleared) · Learn and Be Curious (first WMS migration; learned the floor in month one) · Ownership (the RF miss with my name on the cause)

Process family: Make / Deliver — warehouse execution system cutover across two DCs; inventory-accuracy governance; freeze, failback and hypercare discipline

Honesty label. Full lifecycle owner, accountable to sponsor and Finance; I had never run a WMS migration and learned the floor in month one. Month markers are illustrative unless stated; the RF miss is mine — I scored the task by effort when impact was what mattered. Loop-packet conflict (§1.3): that document says ~$800K budget and ~$2.5M/week; this packet's record is ~$1.8M, ~3% under, ~$2.5M/month — say these.

60-SECOND BUSINESS-FIRST PITCH — STOP ON THE PRIMARY METRIC

Situation. Two Sephora DCs ran on a legacy WMS with no documentation, an eight-month hard deadline, a ~$1.8M budget, and a $20M ROI pipeline of four programs gated behind go-live — about $2.5M a month of slip. Inventory accuracy across two DCs could not wobble at cutover, and I had never run a WMS migration. **Task.** Own the full lifecycle — charter, design sign-off, the ERP ↔ WMS ↔ 3PL ↔ carrier interface inventory, UAT, cutover, hypercare — accountable to the sponsor and Finance. **Action.** I wrote the success criteria in week one — on the date, inside a published reconciliation tolerance, zero accuracy incidents, a numeric hypercare exit — and learned the floor in month one until I could walk receive-to-ship unaided. I built the interface inventory from message logs with an owner and a test cell per contract, set the mapping-table standard as data not code, and published the 0.5% tolerance with Finance before mock one so the number belonged to us before the test. Three mocks were read by cause class, not headline: 7% (units of measure, location names, status vocabularies) → 1.8% (in-transit timing) → 0.3%. Cutover ran a 72-hour in-transit freeze with the legacy system read-only for 30 days. When about 100 of 400 RF devices failed the conversion script, inventory was inside tolerance and the failure was device conversion, not data — so I invoked the rehearsed paper-pick fallback rather than roll back, and told leadership the same day that the training criterion slipped 1.5 weeks while the date did not move. **Result.** Primary metric: inventory reconciliation variance at cutover — 7% → 1.8% → 0.3% against the 0.5% tolerance. On time, about 3% under the ~$1.8M budget (~$54K), the $20M pipeline unblocked the next month — slip avoided, not banked. Hypercare exited week three at under two blockers a day. The RF miss is mine.

SITUATION / TASK — THE BUSINESS PROCESS PROBLEM, SCOPE, SCALE, BASELINES

S — Two DCs on a legacy WMS; zero inherited documentation; a hard eight-month deadline with a $20M ROI pipeline of four programs gated behind go-live (~$2.5M/month of slip); budget ~$1.8M; I had never run a WMS migration. Inventory accuracy across two DCs could not wobble at cutover.

The register at design sign-off: undocumented interface surprises, conversion mismatch above tolerance, and 3PL/carrier freeze non-compliance — each with a trigger, a data-first mitigation and an owner. The one I missed: RF device conversion sat on the log as a task, not a risk.

T — Own the full lifecycle — discovery charter, design sign-off, the ERP ↔ WMS ↔ 3PL ↔ carrier interface inventory, UAT, cutover, hypercare — accountable to the sponsor and Finance. Team: 14 core + 6 DC Ops.

Baselines on the table: conversion mismatch — gated at the 0.5% tolerance signed with Finance before mock 1 (mock 1 opened at 7%) · accuracy incidents allowed: zero · the date — eight months, hard · budget ~$1.8M ·

hypercare exit < 2 blockers/day.

ACTION — THE PROCESS / OPERATING-MODEL REDESIGN, IN GATED PHASES

- **Discovery (month 1)** — sponsor charter in week one (objectives, assumptions, success criteria, phase entry/exit criteria); interface inventory v0 from message logs; systems-impacted table with LOE per owner; the floor walked until I could follow receive → put-away → pick → ship unaided. *Exit bar:* charter signed by sponsor and Finance; every interface has a named owner.
- **Plan & Design (months 2–3)** — design sign-off pack; interface inventory v1 with a test cell per contract; conversion approach — masters → open orders → on-hand → in-transit as its own batch; mapping-table standard (data, not code); the 0.5% tolerance published with Finance before mock 1. *Exit bar:* council sign-off; tolerance signed; stories slotted by business criticality × effort.
- **Build & Test (months 4–7)** — QA demo schedule to DC Ops; UAT entrance memo (function testing done, conversion build done, test data handed off, pre-prod + perf ready) — QA could fail a build; three mock cutovers with written root causes by class: 7% → 1.8% → 0.3%; after the RF miss, the training plan and device-readiness table. *Exit bar:* mock 3 ≤ 0.5% → written go-live recommendation; training sign-off (slipped 1.5 weeks, date held).
- **Cutover & Go-Live (month 8)** — runbook; 72-hour transfer freeze (≥ the longest lane transit); conversion batches; post-load reconciliation; legacy read-only switch; the go/no-go call. ~100 of ~400 RF devices failed the conversion script → the rehearsed paper-pick fallback, not a rollback; leadership told the same day with the slip priced. *Exit bar:* post-load mismatch inside tolerance; ship confirms posting; zero accuracy incidents.
- **Hypercare / Close (4 weeks planned)** — blockers/day read daily; 30-day failback watch (legacy read-only); budget closed; exit memo with the single-point-dependency lesson. *Exit bar:* < 2 blockers/day sustained → exit week 3; ~3% under budget; pipeline programs started the next month.

Influence and ownership. Mine: the charter, the entrance/exit criteria, the interface inventory, the conversion approach, the mapping-table standard, the tolerance, the go/no-go recommendation and the fallback call; the team built, converted, tested and ran the floor; Finance co-owned the tolerance. Because the success criteria were written in week one and signed by sponsor and Finance, nobody negotiated the exit later. The RF miss is mine — I scored the task by effort when impact was what mattered — and it went upstairs the same afternoon with my name on the cause.

> **Designed the process; others own it now.** I designed the charter, the tolerance, the entrance criteria and the mapping-table standard; the team and Finance now run cutovers against them, and the standard outlived the program. **Trade-off put to leadership.** The recommendation to the sponsor outlined the competing metrics — the eight-month date and the $20M pipeline behind it vs training readiness and conversion variance — and held the date while training slipped 1.5 weeks and the 0.5% tolerance did not move.

RESULTS — $ · # · % · TIME · CUSTOMER · QUALITY (CANON NUMBERS ONLY)

- **$** — ~3% under the ~$1.8M budget (~$54K, record); the $20M ROI pipeline unblocked the next month — ~$2.5M/month of slip avoided, not banked; ≈$45K *modeled* paper-pick fallback cost paid deliberately to hold the date; ≈$0.1M *modeled* less inventory in dispute at 0.3% vs 0.5% on an illustrative $50M on-hand.
- **#** — ~100 of ~400 RF devices failed the conversion script — the rehearsed fallback fired; team 14 core + 6 DC Ops across two DCs (record).
- **%** — mock variance 7% → 1.8% → 0.3% against the 0.5% tolerance published with Finance before mock 1 (record).
- **Time** — eight-month deadline held; 72-hour in-transit freeze; legacy read-only for 30 days; training slipped 1.5 weeks while the date did not move; hypercare exited week 3 of 4 (record).
- **Customer** — zero accuracy incidents at cutover; ship confirms posting; post-load mismatch inside tolerance (record exit bars).
- **Quality** — mocks read by cause class, each removing a named defect category; failback rehearsed, never used; the paper-pick contingency rehearsed and used (record).

L6 LEVEL EVIDENCE — what the interviewer pattern-matches against the Amazon L6 functional rubric; every line is this story's canon, no new numbers

L6 DIMENSION	EVIDENCE IN THIS STORY
Ambiguity	An eight-month deadline across two DCs with no charter. I wrote the sponsor charter in week one — objectives, assumptions, success criteria, phase entry/exit criteria — and set the tolerance with Finance before anyone rehearsed.
Scope & influence	14 core + 6 DC Ops across two DCs; Finance co-owned the tolerance; QA could fail a build on my UAT entrance memo; the go/no-go recommendation and the fallback call were mine to the sponsor.
Execution trade-off + mechanism others now own	Date vs readiness: training slipped 1.5 weeks while the date held; a 72-hour transfer freeze (sized to the longest lane) bought conversion integrity. Mechanisms others own now: the 0.5% tolerance, the UAT entrance memo, and the mapping-table standard (data, not code).
Impact (long-term)	Eight-month deadline held; ~3% under the ~$1.8M budget; the $20M ROI pipeline unblocked the next month — ~$2.5M/month of slip avoided, not banked; zero accuracy incidents at cutover.
Process improvement (standard work institutionalized)	Three mock cutovers read by cause class (variance 7% → 1.8% → 0.3% against 0.5%); a 30-day failback watch with legacy read-only; a numeric hypercare exit (< 2 blockers/day sustained).
Complexity & consensus	~100 of ~400 RF devices failed the conversion script on the day — the rehearsed paper-pick fallback fired, leadership was told the same day, the date did not move.
Root cause at scale	The single-point-dependency lesson went into the exit memo; each mock removed a named defect category rather than fixing individual records, so the fix scaled to the whole conversion.

PROBING — CHALLENGE Q&A TUNED TO THIS INTERVIEWER

Infra — Why publish a tolerance before you knew you could hit it?

So the number belonged to Finance and me before the test, not after. Mock one's 7% was the price; mock three's 0.3% was worth it — and the tolerance was never renegotiated.

Infra — How do you read a mock?

Never by the headline alone. Every delta got a root-cause class — units of measure, location drift, status vocabularies, then in-transit timing. If the total shrank without a named cause, the mock was not evidence. 7 → 1.8 → 0.3 each removed a category, and the fixes were mapping tables as data, not code.

Infra — A quarter of the RF devices failed at cutover. Why not roll back?

Because the fallback was rehearsed and the rollback was not needed: inventory was inside tolerance; the failure was device conversion, not data. I paid about $45K of paper-pick productivity — modeled — to protect about $2.5M a month of pipeline, and took the miss upstairs the same afternoon with my name on the cause.

Infra — What was the freeze and why 72 hours?

A 72-hour in-transit freeze, set at or above the longest lane transit, so in-transit could be converted as its own batch with Σ legacy = Σ JDA — the class that took mock two from 1.8% to 0.3%. Legacy stayed read-only for 30 days as the failback.

Infra — The $875K avoided slip — are you banking it?

No. It is record arithmetic — 10.5 days at about $83K a day — on a slip that did not happen; it is the price that made the fallback the obvious call. What I would measure is the pipeline's first program start against plan, which was the next month.

Infra — Lesson, and what rule did you leave behind?

Any single-point dependency in front of an exit criterion gets a what-if plan regardless of estimated effort. Differently: dual-path device conversion on day one, and a device model × OS × script pass/fail table before training week.

THE KEY MATH — THE THREE MOCKS, THE SLIP PRICE AND THE FALLBACK (RECORD PERCENTAGES AND RECORD PAIRS; ILLUSTRATIVE UNITS LABELED)

STEP	QUANTITY	FORMULA → SUBSTITUTION	BASIS	VALUE
1	Mock 1	`M = Σ|Δ| / Σ on-hand = 140,000 / 2,000,000 = 7.0%`	record % on illustrative units; UoM factor 12 on 1% of SKUs dominates	7.0% — 14× the tolerance
2	Mock 2	`36,000 / 2,000,000 = 1.8%`	UoM / location / status mapping tables as data (record %)	1.8%
3	Mock 3	`6,000 / 2,000,000 = 0.3% ≤ 0.5% → go`	72-h freeze + in-transit as its own batch (record %)	0.3% — written go recommendation
4	Budget	`$1,800,000 × 3% = $54,000`	record	~$54K under
5	Slip price	`$2,500,000 / 30 = $83,333/day; 1.5 wk × 7 × $83,333 = $875,000`	record math — avoided, not banked	≈$875K kept off the critical path
6	Fallback	`~100 / ~400 = 25% of devices; paper-pick ≈$45K; $875K / $45K ≈ 19 ≈ 20× cheaper than the slip`	modeled (15–40% slower, $25–35/h)	≈$45K paid deliberately
7	Dispute delta	`(0.5% − 0.3%) × $50,000,000 = $100,000`	illustrative on-hand (modeled)	≈$0.1M one-time

Never "400 devices failed" — ~100 of ~400. Budget and slip framing are this packet's canon; the loop packet differs (§1.3) — do not mix.

Where this lands at Amazon. Cutover discipline in its most literal form — a tolerance published with Finance before the first rehearsal, mocks read by cause class, a freeze sized to the longest lane, a tested failback, a numeric hypercare exit nobody can negotiate, and a rehearsed contingency that fired on the day. Reliability (0.3% against 0.5%, zero accuracy incidents), responsiveness (the decision the same day), cost efficiency (~3% under), the $20M pipeline on the date.

TWIST MAP — LIKELY LP QUESTIONS FROM THIS INTERVIEWER → THE ANGLE TO TAKE WITH S18

LIKELY QUESTION (THIS INTERVIEWER)	LP	ANGLE — WHAT TO EMPHASIZE	SKIP / NEVER SAY
Tell me about a time something went wrong at go-live.	Bias for Action / Ownership	The RF miss: ~100 of ~400 devices; fallback fired, not rollback; leadership told the same day; training slipped 1.5 weeks, the date did not.	Never "400 devices failed"; do not blame the vendor script — the scoring miss was mine.
Tell me about a time you set a standard others thought was too strict.	Insist on the Highest Standards	0.5% published with Finance before mock one; mock one at 7% was the price; never renegotiated.	S2's 98% gate is the primary for this LP — use it first if both land here, S18 second.
Tell me about learning something new fast.	Learn and Be Curious	Never run a WMS migration; charter in week one; the floor walked unaided by end of month one; the mocks were where I proved it.	Do not overclaim WMS configuration — the team converted and built.
Tell me about a time you delivered on a hard date.	Deliver Results	Eight months, both DCs, 0.3% vs 0.5%, ~3% under, $20M pipeline unblocked the next month.	Never bank the $875K or the $2.5M/month — slip avoided.

LIKELY QUESTION (THIS INTERVIEWER)	LP	ANGLE — WHAT TO EMPHASIZE	SKIP / NEVER SAY
How do you design a freeze / failback for a systems cutover?	Functional — migration design	Freeze ≥ longest lane transit; in-transit as its own batch; legacy read-only 30 days; rollback triggers as numbers (mismatch > 0.5% for 2 days; ship-confirm posting failing > 2 h).	Keep budget at ~$1.8M and slip at ~$2.5M/month (loop-packet conflict).
What did you miss and what did you change?	Ownership	RF conversion on the log as a task, not a risk; the rule left behind: any single-point dependency in front of an exit criterion gets a what-if plan.	Do not soften it — "the miss is mine."

Question bank — likely questions for this interviewer, with a one-line answer plan

Behavioral and functional questions a Senior Manager of Infrastructure is likely to ask. Each plan points at a packet story or a named backup in the master packet; stories allocated to other interviewers are pointers only.

#	LIKELY QUESTION	ANSWER PLAN (ONE LINE)	STORY
1	**Tell me about the most complex physical / systems change you have led in a DC.**	S2 pitch — one pool, three planning identities, two go-lives, the 98% gate; end on +15% signed and zero incidents.	S2
2	**Tell me about a migration or cutover you ran.**	S18 pitch — tolerance before mock one; 7 → 1.8 → 0.3; the RF fallback; on time, ~3% under.	S18
3	**How do you decide a program is ready to go live?**	Counted rows, not confidence: Blocker + Critical = 0; mock inside tolerance; runbook rehearsed; rollback armed; a written recommendation.	S2 / S18
4	**How do you ramp automation without hurting throughput?**	Publish the gate from the pre-ramp baseline and the incident budget; build the throttle in advance; the floor owner owns the dial; RCA before re-ramp.	S2
5	**What are your rollback triggers, typically?**	Numbers per interface: sync < 99% for 4 h; p95 > 2× budget for 1 h (S2); mismatch > 0.5% for two days; ship-confirm posting failing > 2 h (S18).	S2 / S18
6	**How do you handle a vendor slipping on your critical path (Locus RTL)?**	Escalate the week it surfaces; re-slot openly; refuse to compress UAT to absorb it; retest after the slip.	S2
7	**Tell me about a time a rehearsed contingency saved you.**	Paper-pick fallback for ~100 of ~400 RF devices; ≈$45K modeled vs ≈$875K of slip avoided; the date held.	S18
8	**How do you exit hypercare?**	A number written before go-live: < 2 blockers/day sustained; S2 exited week 3 of 4 on 271 → 65 → 21 → 14 → 4; S18 exited week 3. A calendar exit declares victory over open defects.	S2 / S18
9	**How would you approach consolidating or launching a node in the NACF network?**	Master §3.99 opening — book of record and metric → stocks and flows → the invariant broken today (a unit sellable in two places) → staged go-lives → ramp gate → hypercare number.	Master §3.99 + S2
10	**What is the utilization impact of consolidation?**	+15% units per labor-hour signed; one pool (√2 pooling, modeled); self-transfers to zero by construction; robots at full volume week three.	S2
11	**Tell me about a failure.**	S18's RF miss in full — the scoring error, the fallback, the same-day escalation, the rule left behind.	S18
12	**How do you keep peak safe during a multi-system program?**	The Oct–Dec freeze decided as a council decision; the staged timeline around it; E2E days dated before and after; no release through peak.	S2

Cheat-numbers box — canon values with basis labels

Canon numbers for S2 and S18 with their basis labels, from the master packet's §4.1 ledger.

METRIC	VALUE TO SAY	BASIS	NEVER
S2 efficiency	+15% processing efficiency (index 100 → 115)	record, Sephora-signed, measured by DC Ops post-stabilization	presenting the dollars as signed
S2 incidents	zero customer-facing incidents through both go-lives	record	—
S2 robotics gate	98% published; week 2 at 94; ~30% throttle for a week; full volume week 3	record	"the robots failed"
S2 dollars	≈$1.6M/yr (0.88 labor · 0.22 carry · 0.45 splits · 0.10 self-transfer); ≈$2.2M one-time pooling; range $1.1–2.4M/yr	modeled on an illustrative 100K-units/week DC	—
S2 scale	a dozen core systems, 20+ touched; 60+ stakeholders (~80 names, ~15 functions); ~30 build tracks	record	"12 systems" alone or "20 systems" alone; a single stakeholder count
S2 artifacts / dates	343 tasks / ~815 hrs; 836 rows / 85.4% closed; council 5/15 → 7/31 → FSD 8/14; E2E 11/22 · 12/20 · 1/30; Jan + May go-lives	record (program-level artifacts shared with S1/S5)	—
S2 rollback triggers	sync < 99% for 4 h; order-flow p95 > 2× budget for 1 h — armed twice, never fired	record	—
S18 mocks	7% → 1.8% → 0.3% vs 0.5% tolerance published with Finance before mock 1	record	—
S18 date / budget	8 months, on time; ~$1.8M, ~3% under (~$54K)	record (this packet's canon; loop packet differs)	"~$800K"
S18 pipeline	$20M ROI pipeline unblocked the next month; ~$2.5M/month of slip	record; slip avoided, not banked	"$2.5M/week"; banking the ~$875K
S18 RF miss	~100 of ~400 devices; paper-pick fallback; training +1.5 weeks; date held	record	"400 devices failed"
S18 freeze / failback / exit	72-hour in-transit freeze; legacy read-only 30 days; hypercare exit week 3 at < 2 blockers/day	record	—
S18 modeled	≈$45K fallback cost; ≈$0.1M less inventory in dispute (illustrative $50M on-hand)	modeled	—

Never-say, one glance before the call.

- Never "400 devices failed" — ~100 of ~400.
- Never bank the $20M pipeline, the ~$2.5M/month or the ~$875K — slip avoided, not banked.

- Never "12 systems" or "20 systems" alone — a dozen core, 20+ touched; never a single stakeholder count.
- Never present the ≈$1.6M/yr or the ≈$2.2M pooling as signed — the +15% and the zero are the record.
- Never claim BlueYonder or Locus configuration — vendor and platform teams built and configured; I owned the model, staging, gates and go/no-go.
- S1/S3/S5 share the UDC program's dated chain — they are Lan's; S11/S12, S6/S8 and the bar raiser's four stay out of this room.

Backup bench — use only if a primary doesn't fit

Three fallbacks for an infrastructure owner: S13 (Manhattan — Cyber Monday at 4 AM; the incident-response / Bias for Action alternate to S18, and the older pair for S2's throttle), S5 (Sephora — the architecture council without owning a system; governance of a 20+-system change, same program family as S2 — never pair S5 with S2 for this interviewer unless asked for a second UDC example) and S15 (Sephora — the QA cadence conversion; the people / Hire & Develop question — Josyula's primary, so only if the question demands it). Tell S2 and S18 first.

Bench discipline. The two (or four) primaries above are the stories to tell first. Reach for a bench story only when the question genuinely does not fit a primary, or when the interviewer asks for "another example" on an LP already spent. Each entry is a 60-second pitch, a compressed STAR, one results line and two probes — enough to answer and stop; no full probing bank or derivation. Where a bench story is another interviewer's primary, the red note says so: use it only if the question demands it, and keep the facts identical to that packet.

BACKUP — ONLY IF ASKED S13 — Manhattan — Cyber Monday, 4 AM: allocation across 3 DCs and 100 stores when the scheduler died

LPs this backup can serve: Bias for Action (primary) · Customer Obsession (primary backup — the promise ranked first) · Deliver Results

Basis. OMS consultant on allocation, promising and the OMS–WMS handshake; engineering fixed the scheduler once I isolated it; the post-mortem mechanisms were mine to drive. $8M / $6M / 99% are record; the margin figures are my model at benchmark rates. Older story — if asked for recent, pair with the UDC robotics throttle (S2): same muscle, 2024–25.

60-SECOND PITCH — STOP ON THE PRIMARY METRIC

Situation. Manhattan OMS consultant on allocation and promising across 3 DCs and 100 stores; 4 AM Cyber Monday the VP called — backorders piling with inventory present, ~$6M of sales at risk against a 95% fill-rate goal. **Task.** Own the response before the root cause was known. **Action.** Discovery: the contradiction (ATP > 0, backorders rising) was the entry bar to declare an incident. Plan & Design: I ranked by promise-at-risk, not FIFO; node choice = the promise — near 0.85 days vs far 4.60. Build & Test: one bridge, every rebalance timestamped; reason-coded alerts I had already built. Cutover: rebalanced so no DC drowned; status every two hours until 9 PM. Hypercare: root cause — the allocation scheduler died silently at the daylight-saving change; the post-mortem shipped a heartbeat, a DST checklist, a 3σ page rule and a rehearsed rebalance playbook. Lesson: decide reversibly, log it, find the cause later. **Result.** Primary metric: peak fill rate — 95% goal → 99% delivered. ~$8M of peak sales protected against ~$6M at risk (record); my model puts that at ≈$3.2M of gross margin at a 40% benchmark margin; structural stockouts −20% over the engagement.

COMPRESSED STAR

- **S —** 4 AM Cyber Monday: backorder lines piling with inventory present; promises aging; ~$6M at risk against a 95% fill goal; nobody had written a clearing rule for failure.
- **T —** Own the response before the cause was known, without making it worse.
- **A —** Declared the incident on the contradiction; clearing rule — promise-at-risk, not FIFO — written on the bridge log in the first hour so nobody re-argued it at noon; rebalanced across three DCs; two-hourly status; isolated the DST scheduler death through my own reason-coded alerts; blameless post-mortem → heartbeat, DST checklist, 3σ page rule, rehearsed playbook.
- **R —** Fill 99% vs the 95% goal; ~$8M protected vs ~$6M at risk (record pair); structural stockouts −20% over the engagement; the next peak ran boring.

RESULTS LINE

Peak fill 99% vs the 95% goal (record) · ~$8M of peak sales protected vs ~$6M at risk (record pair — one-time sales that didn't die, never a saving) · ≈$3.2M gross margin at a 40% benchmark (modeled) · structural stockouts −20% over the engagement (record) · detection moved from a VP phone call to one heartbeat interval.

TWO PROBES

> **Why act before you knew the cause?**
>
> Because waiting had an hourly price — the queue was aging while inventory sat idle — and a reversible, logged intervention did not. I checked with engineering first that manual clears could not corrupt allocation, timestamped every rebalance, and hunted the cause in parallel with alerts I had already built.

> **Isn't this a hero story?**
>
> The event is; the post-mortem is the point. Carrying the first stretch solo is one of my do-differentlys. What I would present as the result is the mechanism set — heartbeat, DST checklist, 3σ page rule, rehearsed playbook — and that the next peak ran boring.

Canon numbers (basis labels): 99% fill vs 95% goal (record) · ~$8M protected vs ~$6M at risk (record) · 3 DCs / 100 stores (record) · near 0.85 d vs far 4.60 d (record) · −20% structural stockouts (record) · ≈$3.2M margin at 40% (modeled). Never "$2MM baseline"; never present $8M as a saving.

BACKUP — ONLY IF ASKED S5 — Sephora — the architecture council without owning any system: three decisions and a fence

LPs this backup can serve: Have Backbone; Disagree & Commit (third) · Earn Trust (influence without authority) · Think Big (architecture governance). Same program family as S1/S2 — the governance story

Basis. I owned none of the systems; the design decision was the deliverable. Zero escalations and the dated gate chain are the record; the dollars are my model of what governance avoided.

60-SECOND PITCH — STOP ON THE PRIMARY METRIC

Situation. The UDC location and inventory model had to clear architecture council — a challenge gate — with ~80 named participants across ~15 functions, and I owned none of those systems. **Task.** Take the design from discovery through council to sign-off and FSD without a surprise escalation. **Action.** Discovery: both inventory books profiled before any design argument; business sessions closed 4/30. Plan & Design: every impacted row pre-wired with a signed LOE by 7/2; the council asked for three separable decisions plus an out-of-scope fence (reserve math untouched; MCS decommission belongs to Global ERP). Build & Test: the "build" was the pack — architecture, staged timeline, peak-freeze boundary. Cutover: 5/15 challenge → 7/31 sign-off → 8/14 FSD. Hypercare: the fence held in writing for the whole program; a second live warehouse became a monitored shadow copy, not an argument. Lesson: a no that lives in a document survives. **Result.** Primary metric: surprise escalations on a 60+ stakeholder design — the norm on prior programs → zero; the dated gate chain held. ≈$0.5M one-time modeled (avoided rework on ~3 escalations that never happened + six weeks of benefit not deferred + a fenced second reserve engine not built).

COMPRESSED STAR

- **S —** A dozen core systems (20+ touched), ~80 participants across ~15 functions, a council that re-litigates designs this size — and I owned none of the systems.
- **T —** Discovery (kickoff 3/29, sessions 4/30) → council 5/15 → sign-off 7/31 → FSD 8/14, without a surprise escalation.
- **A —** Profiled both books first — their numbers, not my opinion; systems-impacted table with an owner on every row; one LOE template, one deadline (7/2), one private conversation per owner before the room; three separable decisions plus the fence; the second-truth objection converted into a monitored shadow copy.
- **R —** Surprise escalations → 0 for the program's life; 100% pre-wire coverage by 7/2; gate chain held to the day with zero re-litigation; fence breaches 0; handed clean into the build (S2).

RESULTS LINE

Surprise escalations → 0 for the program's life (record) · gate chain 3/29 → 4/30 → 5/15 → 7/2 → 7/31 → 8/14 held to the day (record) · pre-wire coverage 100% — every impacted row with a signed LOE by 7/2 (record) · both scope refusals held in writing; fence breaches 0 (record) · ≈$0.5M one-time (modeled — what did not happen).

TWO PROBES

How do you get sixty people to sign LOE you don't control?

A template, a deadline and a private conversation each — so nobody learned their cost in the room. The council was then asked for three separable decisions it could take one at a time; separability was the design.

What did you refuse, and did it hold?

Retuning the reserve math and folding in the MCS decommission — both written, signed and held; later scope requests were answered from the pack in writing. The legitimate concern (a second live warehouse becoming a second truth) was converted into the design as a monitored shadow copy, because converting a concern costs less than winning it.

Canon numbers (basis labels): ~80 participants / ~15 functions; a dozen core systems, 20+ touched (record) · 5/15 → 7/31 → 8/14; LOE 7/2 (record dates) · escalations 0; fence breaches 0 (record) · ≈$0.5M one-time (modeled). Never a dollar as record; never pair with S1 or S2 for the same interviewer.

BACKUP — ONLY IF ASKED S15 — Sephora — converting a 20-person Product/Engineering/QA team to a four-week cadence in six weeks — and the QA lead who now owns the gate

LPs this backup can serve: Hire and Develop the Best (primary) · Strive to be Earth's Best Employer (QA elevated, not blamed) · Insist on the Highest Standards (the gate)

Josyula's primary (Packet 5, Hire & Develop the Best) — use only if the question demands it, and keep every fact identical to that packet.

Basis. VP air cover, no line authority over anyone in the room; the QA lead authored the definition-of-done — I coached the frame, she owned the gate. The −50% and the six weeks are record; the dollars are my model on illustrative defect counts. Never invent a direct-report headcount.

60-SECOND PITCH — STOP ON THE PRIMARY METRIC

Situation. The VP asked me to move a 20-person Product/Eng/QA team from a six-week hybrid cadence to four-week agile; QA feared compressed test windows — and they were right. **Task.** Convert in weeks without line authority. **Action.** Discovery: one-on-ones; an influencer per function. Plan & Design: the QA lead authored the definition-of-done — I coached the frame, she owned the gate. Build & Test: Jira benefit-ranking and review-status fields; a QA drop date with reason codes. Cutover: the four-week cadence live in six weeks. Hypercare: QA on product-business calls with pre-approved scenarios; she defended the gate without me. Lesson: development that depends on me staying is not development. **Result.** Primary metric: critical defects per release −50% after the 20-person team moved to a four-week cadence in six weeks. ≈$130K/yr modeled — the −50% and the six weeks are the record; the dollars are my model; no headcount invented.

COMPRESSED STAR

- **S —** Six-week hybrid cadence; QA (a contracting firm) and engineering (in-house) heading for a standoff; QA's fear of compressed test windows was correct arithmetic, not resistance.
- **T —** Convert to four weeks in weeks, with VP air cover and no line authority.
- **A —** Heard every real objection privately; the QA lead wrote the DoD content and entry criteria that can say no; drop date with reason codes; Jira fields; Sev-1 cause classification; rollback to six weeks named as a two-way door at kickoff and never used; facilitated the retro once and stepped back.
- **R —** Converted in six weeks; critical defects per release −50% while shipping 50% more releases (8.7 → 13/yr modeled from the cadence); the gate survived my leaving; neighbouring teams copied the ceremony from the user guide.

RESULTS LINE

Critical defects per release −50% (record) · six-week → four-week cadence, converted in six weeks (record) · 20-person team (record); releases/yr 8.7 → 13 (modeled from the cadence) · ≈$130K/yr (modeled; range $80–270K; no headcount invented) · the QA lead defending the gate by cycle 2 (record).

TWO PROBES

Who did you develop, concretely?

The QA lead — she authored the definition-of-done and its entry criteria, and by cycle two she was defending the gate on product-business calls without me. The test of development is that it survived my leaving; it did.

What did engineering give up?

Low-impact stories they had to drop at the QA drop date — I covered those with the business. Their objection became co-ownership through review, not a veto over the gate.

Canon numbers (basis labels): −50% critical defects per release (record) · 6 weeks to convert; 6-week → 4-week cadence (record) · 20 people (record) · 8.7 → 13 releases/yr (modeled) · ≈$130K/yr (modeled). Never a direct-report headcount.